

PARTISAN SUPPORT
People from the Meitei community protest the violence at Jantar Mantar in Delhi

WHAT'S FUELLING THE FIRE

- The administration is sharply divided on ethnic lines between two communities—Meitei and Kuki—and often failing on professional responsibilities
- Police force remained mute spectators when weapons were looted from state armouries; both communities are now armed, carrying out arson attacks
- State political leaders are allegedly backing Meitei vigilante groups, who claim that Central government and armed forces are unwilling to take strict action against Kuki militants involved in violence
- Provocative comments by political leaders and civil society groups of both sides are adding to the conflict; there is little action against such statements
- Both Meiteis and Kukis say peaceful co-existence is no longer possible; violence is a way to grab maximum land from each other

could arm themselves against aggressors. "A Meitei friend of mine, who is a senior cop in Churachandpur, could not intervene when mobs looting arms were helped by Kuki policemen," says Prof. Bhagat Oinam of Jawaharlal Nehru University. "Besides, the mobs easily outnumbered the police personnel on most occasions." That the lines between the protectors and perpetrators were blurred was proven by CCTV footage from June 13 of a group wearing Rapid Action Force (RAF) uniforms and wielding shields and weapons vandalising cars in Imphal West.

The allegations of bias run from the lower constabulary to the top cop of the state and to the political leadership. To instil a sense of balance, Director General of Police (DGP) P. Doungel, a Kuki, was replaced with Rajiv Singh, an IPS officer of the Tripura cadre, but it hasn't helped. Ten Kuki MLAs, including seven from the ruling BJP, are demanding a separate administration for Kukis. One of them, Paolienlal Haokip, the BJP legislator from Saikot, has openly accused chief minister N. Biren Singh of siding with the Meiteis. The MHA has now appointed former NIA and CRPF DIG Kuldeep Singh as advisor to the CM.

Even the armed forces have not escaped blame. Several Meitei groups claimed the paramilitary force Assam Rifles and the central government were soft on Kuki militant groups subject to the 2008 Suspension of Operation (SoO) agreement. They say these groups led the attacks against the Meiteis. What has lent credence to this charge is a PIL filed in an NIA court on June 8 by S.S. Haokip, chairman of the United Kuki Liberation Front (UKLF), one of the armed outfits under the SoO. It included a 2019 letter written by Haokip to Union home minister Amit Shah. In it, Haokip claimed that the UKLF and another Kuki group, the United Peoples' Front (UPF), had helped BJP candidates win in the assembly election, as per an agreement with Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma and former BJP in-charge of the Northeast, Ram Madhav. They also helped the BJP in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls, claimed the letter. In the 2022 assembly polls, the Kuki National Organisation (KNO), an umbrella group of 17 insurgent groups, and UPF, representing eight other Kuki outfits, had publicly extended support to BJP candidates in Kuki areas.

The revelations have naturally fuelled conspiracy theories. If Kuki groups claim that Biren Singh took over 24 hours to issue shoot-at-sight orders after Meitei-fuelled violence erupted on May 3, the Union government has been accused of dithering on revoking the SoO agreement with Kuki groups because of previous political support.

On March 10, the state government unilaterally withdrew the SoO agreement with two groups—Kuki National Army (KNA) and Zomi Revolutionary Army (ZRA)—alleging they were instigating people against its drive to evict illegal encroachers from forest lands. Sources say they have also been arming Kuki villagers. On May 25, 12 Meitei BJP leg-